

Spies

Spying, or espionage, is all about finding out secret information, known as “intelligence”. Spies have been operating for thousands of years. In ancient times, they sneaked into enemy camps to uncover their battle plans. If they were caught, they were killed. Spying is still a dangerous business. Secret agents carry weapons as well as the latest surveillance gadgets.

CAMERAS

Used to photograph top-secret plans or provide evidence of a private meeting, the camera is an essential part of a spy's kit. These days, a secret agent can use a smartphone to take a snap without attracting attention. In the past, cameras had to be ingeniously concealed inside everyday objects.



MICRODOT CAMERA



DCD-1 (CIA SUBMINIATURE CAMERA)



WRAL (CIA SUBMINIATURE CAMERA)



MOLLY (CIA SUBMINIATURE CAMERA)



WRISTWATCH CAMERA



INSECTOHOPTER (FLYING SURVEILLANCE CAMERA)



Lighter flips open to reveal camera

LIGHTER CAMERA

FAMOUS SPIES

Successful spies rarely become famous, because their cover is never blown. A handful of spies do find fame as heroes, or after being found guilty of espionage.

JOHN ANDRE

This British army officer was hanged as a spy in 1780 during the American War of Independence.

JAMES ARMISTEAD LAFAYETTE

A former African slave, Lafayette was a double agent in the War of Independence.

MATA HARI

Dutch dancer Mata Hari was executed for spying for Germany in World War I (1914–18).

VIRGINIA HALL

After helping the British in World War II (1939–45), this US spy joined the CIA.

THE ROSENBERGS

This American husband and wife were executed in 1953 for passing secrets to the Soviet Union.



MATA HARI

THE FICTIONAL SPY JAMES BOND WAS CREATED BY IAN FLEMING IN 1953

RADIOS

Radio allowed secret agents of the past to communicate quickly over long distances – they did so in code, because radio messages can be easily intercepted. Radio waves also transmitted sounds from listening devices, such as the one hidden in the hotel lamp below.



RADIO WRISTWATCH KGB



PORTABLE MILITARY RADIO



ATTACHE CASE RADIO



HOTEL LAMP TRANSCEIVER

RECORDING DEVICES

With the help of bugs and other secret recording devices, spies can ensure that no conversation is ever private. Wiretaps allow an agent to listen in on phone conversations.



CIA WRISTWATCH MICROPHONE



MEZON RECORDING DEVICE



PEN-TOP MICROPHONE

CODES AND CIPHERS

Keeping communications secret and intercepting enemy messages were prime concerns during World War I and II. Codes allow words or instructions to be replaced by letters, numbers, or symbols. Ciphers are a clever kind of code, where a secret “key” encrypts the message.



M-94 CIPHER DEVICE



MORSE CODE KEY



LETTER-REMOVING DEVICE



HANDKERCHIEF WITH SECRET WRITING



GERMAN ENIGMA CIPHER MACHINE USED BY JAPANESE



GERMAN ENIGMA CIPHER MACHINE